

Q12) To what extent should foreign talent be welcomed in your society?

Key words:

To what extent: How far/ to what degree should foreign talent be accepted or embraced

Should : Implications of the word 'should':

- Is it right?
- Is it necessary?
- Is it desirable?
- Does it serve our interest? ...to welcome foreign talent

Foreign talent:

Foreign talent refer to foreigners with professional qualifications or acceptable degrees working at the higher end of Singapore's economy. Broadly speaking, refer to Professionals, Managers , Executives, Technicians (PMETs)

Approach:

A Address the proposition that foreign talent should be welcomed in Singapore – because they bring with them advantages and benefits.

B Argue that while it is necessary and desirable to welcome foreign talent, it cannot be done at the expense of local talent and workers.

Suggested arguments

Part A: Foreign talent should be welcomed in Singapore

- 1. Foreign talent should be welcomed in Singapore as we require the knowledge and expertise of foreign talent that are lacking in our own local population to build new industries and sustain economic growth.**
 - There is expectation/obligation on the part of the government to sustain economic dynamism and foreign talent are essential to help in rejuvenating and expanding Singapore's talent base.
 - Foreign talent can bring with them different skills, experiences and knowledge that are complementary to the local workforce, especially those who have vast experience helming big corporations or expertise in science and technological industries. This is crucial to our long-term competitiveness, and ensures that we stay relevant to a dynamic region that is fast evolving and growing.
 - The growth of new industries is generating demand for workers with specialised skills such as cyber security and artificial intelligence. While locals are being trained with the relevant skill, it will take some time before the supply of local workers with the right skills can meet the soaring demand. Info-communication technology and Finance technology (Fintech) are fast-moving and market demand can shift quickly in response in advances in trends and technology
- 2. Welcoming foreign talent will signal our openness as a globalised and cosmopolitan economy and make us attractive to foreigners, nurture our image as a liveable city and continue to attract highly mobile talent to grow our society.**

- Given the current climate of protectionism – Europe and the US not welcoming towards foreign talent, if we continue to welcome foreign talent, it will cement our status as an open, globalised society. This is both to improve citizens' everyday lives and to boost competitiveness by ensuring Singapore is an attractive place to live for top talent. It is desirable and makes good sense to embrace foreign talent with open hearts as Singapore is now a regional hub for many of the world's multinationals.
- Eg: MNCs like Johnson & Johnson and Proctor & Gamble, Google, that have chosen Singapore as their regional headquarters. They have expanded and set up innovation and leadership development centres here. These have in turn provided Singaporeans with exciting jobs with global opportunities. Allowing more of such companies into Singapore will help us as the nation embarks on its next phase of growth and transitions to an innovation-driven economy.

3. With Singapore facing the problem of an ageing population and a shrinking labour force, foreign talent are needed to make up for our shortage of talent. Crucial industries require us to bring in foreign talent to sustain core industries and sectors requiring highly skilled workers such as healthcare where it is even more urgent due to an ageing population.

- With a fertility rate of only 1.6, far below the replacement rate of 2.1, given that more resources will then have to be expended to support the elderly, Singapore will find it very difficult to develop and compete with its neighbouring countries. Singapore may not have enough people needed to drive the fast growth of the past.
- As a mid-sized city, Singapore does not have the quantity of manpower needed to drive a modern economy forward. It is not feasible to survive solely based on the domestic labour market which is shrinking as we speak. It is necessary to rely on international migrant flows as it is also fuelled by the country's low fertility rates and ageing population. The resident birth rate has been declining over the past 20 years. This means fewer residents in each subsequent cohorts entering the labour force. As at 2016, the net resident labour supply growth is nearly flat as the number of people leaving the workforce is roughly similar to the number joining it. Projecting forward to 2020, without migration, Singapore's labour force will start shrinking. There will be fewer workers to support the economy. Businesses may find it difficult to get the manpower they need and decide to locate elsewhere, bringing along the jobs with them. Businesses may find it difficult to get the manpower they need and decide to locate elsewhere, bringing along the jobs with them.

B. Argue that while it is necessary and desirable to welcome foreign talent in the country, we should not be indiscriminate in the numbers and quality of foreign talent that we are bringing in.

4. Nonetheless, we should not welcome too many foreign talent because doing so will compromise the livelihood and welfare of the locals.

- It is essential to maintain a healthy balance between keeping Singapore open to foreign talent and ensuring locals are given fair consideration in jobs.
- Many Singaporeans have questioned the need for companies to import so many foreign talent to fill up job positions which can be easily filled by locals. There have been many cases of Professionals, Managers, Executives and Technicians (PMETs) going out of work and facing difficulty securing employment once they are past the age of 40 reported in the news. In reality, the rapid influx of foreign talent benefits businesses disproportionately. All too often, we hear of companies firing lower to middle management personnel and then immediately re-hiring batches

of fresh foreign recruits who can be paid a lower salary. This happened, for example, in the last recession.

- Taking Singapore Post as an example of a thriving Singaporean business, sitting on the board is Aliza Knox, who originally hails from the US. Ms Knox is currently the Head of Asia at Cloudflare, Inc. and is a Non-Executive Director of Scentre Group. Knox used to head digital APAC sales at Google. Another director is Michael Murphy who is also the CEO and founder of a US postal technology group and brings a degree in nuclear engineering and connections to MIT's graduate programme.
- Arguably their international experience lends a diverse and competitive edge to SingPost. Nonetheless having highly experienced local executives at the helm must still form the bedrock of any Singapore business and in this case foreign directors at SingPost only total 25% of the board. Yet 38% of Singapore's workforce are foreign – considerably more than 25%.

5. Even though foreign talent are needed for sustained economic growth, welcoming too many foreign talent or foreign talent who are unable to integrate successfully into our society may lead to societal tensions and affect national cohesion.

- Foreign talent have a higher likelihood of staying permanently in Singapore as they are better educated, hold good jobs and are in the end more likely to be offered permanent residency or citizenship. However, this has given rise to tensions between locals as many still see foreign talent as outsiders despite a change in their citizenship status due to differences in culture, behaviours and attitudes. A number of locals are also unhappy with foreign talent as they see foreign talent as fuelling the competition for housing, educational degrees etc.
- Some foreign talent may display a lack of cultural sensitivity and create tensions in society. Xenophobic sentiments were displayed as seen in the case of the Anton Casey saga. The British expatriate caused a furore in Singapore in 2014 when he referred to public transport commuters in Singapore as "poor people" in his Facebook post. This was in addition to the derogatory remarks he had posted on Facebook about a taxi driver in Singapore having a towel on his lap and wearing gloves while driving. His posts angered many in Singapore, even leading Law Minister K. Shanmugam to post a response on Facebook, calling Casey's comments "deeply offensive, wrong and unacceptable". Casey lost his job at wealth management firm Crossinvest (Asia), and was forced to leave Singapore with his family for Perth in Western Australia, after threats were reportedly made against them.